Fully Illuminating the Essence: A Commentary on the Excellent Coemergent Yoga

Sahajasadyogavṛttigarbhaprakāśa · Toh 1247 · Derge Tengyur
ལྷན་ཅིག་སྐྱེས་པའ་རྣལ་འབྱོར་དམ་པའ་འགལ་པ་སྙིང་པ་རོབ་ཏུ་གྲུས་ལ་བར་བའྱེ་པ

Fully Illuminating the Essence, a Commentary on the Excellent Coemergent Yoga, known in Sanskrit as the Sahajasadyogavṛttigarbhaprakāśa and in Tibetan as Lhenchik Kyepé Naljor Dampé Drelpa Nyingpo Rabtu Salwar Jepa, is an Indian commentary on a short work on coemergent yoga drawn from the Hevajra Tantra and composed by the scholar Ratnākaraśānti. It explains the completion stage of Hevajra practice: how the coemergent bliss of the four joys is experienced, how it relates to the dharmakāya and the saṃbhogakāya, how the yogin practices with the four seals in and out of meditative equipoise, and the four states in which the coemergent appears, like clouds, like an illusion, like a dream, and like dream and waking. Its colophon names the brahmin Thagana, a master from Oḍḍiyāna, as its author, and records that it was translated into Tibetan by an Indian paṇḍita. It is Toh 1247 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the commentaries on the tantras.

In the language of India: sahajasadyogavṛttigarbhaprakāśenāma. In the language of Tibet: The Commentary on the Excellent Coemergent Yoga, called Fully Illuminating the Essence.

Homage to glorious Vajraḍāka.

He for whom the supreme abode becomes his sphere of activity,
Through whom the world, filled with the impurity of the net of manifold concepts,
Attains the stainless and limitless state:
To that peerless Vajra Protector I bow my head.

That which is realized by distinguishing the conventional and the ultimate,
Two and yet a nondual essence, formidable,
From which the state of experiencing the coemergent is attained:
To that supreme deity, worthy of offering, I pay homage.

Drawn from the tantra of Hevajra,
Composed by the glorious Ratnākara,
Pure through the investigation of excellent intellect,
The coemergent yoga I shall now analyze.

To begin with, the master, by means of the fitting verse of homage that begins "Hevajra, together with its concordant outflow, the supreme," sets out the subject matter of the entire treatise. That is the condensed meaning. Its extensive explanation is this. "Having bowed deeply to the supreme wheel of yoginīs" means: having paid homage, I shall explain how clear realization comes about in the context of the completion stage. That is the connection of the words. Clear realization is that treatise by which the wheel of yoginīs and the nature of Hevajra come to be realized beforehand and without error. The completion stage is the stage of what is accomplished by its own nature.

If one asks what that wheel of yoginīs is like: "Hevajra, together with its concordant outflow" means that the concordant outflow is what resembles its cause, and "together with" means together with that. Hevajra himself is the concordant outflow; it should be understood as "together with that." "The supreme" is the coemergent nature of the dharmakāya. Why is that? Because here, through the full contact of the banner and the supreme limb, the drop of the mind of awakening drips into the wheel of great bliss, and one experiences its very nature as joy and the rest. That experience of the bliss of the exemplary coemergent is the coemergent of the saṃbhogakāya, and that itself is what is explained as being called Hevajra. Moreover, the essence that arises from the example is explained as the concordant outflow of the nominal wheel of yoginīs, whose nature is the coemergent of the dharmakāya. For, as it is said:

From these, that which is like the sky,
That protector is the dharmakāya;
That which is like the full moon
Is the saṃbhogakāya.

And as is said further on, in the passage beginning:

That itself is the wheel of yoginīs,
Which is nondual wisdom.

Accordingly, reaching the lord of the stars at the tip of the vajra jewel is the experience of the coemergent of the saṃbhogakāya. The experience of the nonconceptual dharmadhātu is the coemergent of the dharmakāya. When the hare-marked one issues from the vajra and abides within the lake-born one, then it should be connected with the nirmāṇakāya. This is the oral instruction of the earlier masters teaching the three bodies.

For this verse of homage, too, the connection and the rest should be understood. The clear realization of the completion stage is the expression, and the wheel of yoginīs and Hevajra are what is to be expressed. Between them, in terms of general characteristics, the connection is that between the means and the thing that arises from the means. Experiencing the two kinds of coemergent, whose nature is conventional and ultimate, is the purpose. Having oneself experienced the coemergent and then fully teaching that very thing to others as well, so accomplishing awakening, is the purpose of the purpose.

Now, in order to explain the completion stage taught by the Teacher in the eighth chapter of the first part, it is said:

Having imagined the realm of space as the bhaga,
One should meditate in its center:
The wheel, the prior, as is fitting,
The deities, as they arose.

Its meaning for the generation stage is this. After meditating on emptiness, one visualizes the seal of the source of phenomena, and upon it, "the wheel, the prior, as is fitting, the deities" means that one fully imagines the four maṇḍalas beginning with the wheel, and after that the yogin should carry out the set of activities. That is the brief teaching. The words "as they arose" indicate the meditator. Why is that? Because whatever is meditated upon through the sequence of the maṇḍala and so forth has a form that is nondual with the mind of the meditator. As is said in the eighth chapter, on selflessness:

The wheel is earth, the prior is water,
As is fitting is fire,
The deities, the great nāga,
As they arose is the meditator.

Here too, the earth and so forth indicated by the words "wheel" and the rest are taught in the Garland of Pearls by way of the symbolic code of the Dharma, or by way of knowledge, and they should be understood from that text. That is the provisional meaning. Its meaning is this. In order to explain the definitive meaning by way of the extensive explanation through "activity" and the rest: in "Having made the agent enter the place," the banner enters the lake-born one. "The practitioner should perform the activity" means that at the time of practice the yogin should perform the activities made blissful by the bliss of

going and coming and so forth. After that, "at the moment of experiencing the practitioner's limb, the fruit is the wheel of yoginīs" teaches this: one experiences the first three limbs as having the nature of flowing, and the fruit is the essence of the nonconceptual nature of reality, which the word "wheel of yoginīs" is to bring about, the nominal form of the coemergent of the dharmakāya, whose nature is unsurpassed and nondual great bliss.

In "Its concordant outflow is Heruka," the concordant outflow of that which is the coemergent of the dharmakāya, whose nature arises from the example, is the effect concordant with its cause. That is to say, Heruka, characterized as the coemergent of the saṃbhogakāya whose nature is the example, is the essence of the conventional mind of awakening.

That the saṃbhogakāya and the nirmāṇakāya arise from the dharmakāya through the power of former aspirations is indeed taught in the Great Vehicle as well. Elsewhere, too, it is taught:

Through the mere presence of that being,
Who is like a wish-fulfilling jewel,
Teachings from walls and the like
Arise according to what each one wishes.

Therefore here too, the example: because, by its coemergent nature, it arises from the example of the saṃbhogakāya, it is explained as the concordant outflow of the dharmakāya. Here too, the saṃbhogakāya is pervaded by the dharmakāya, whose nature is to pervade, and so it is explained as the very concordant outflow of the dharmakāya.

The passage beginning "In the aspect of generation" sets out, one by one, the coemergent nature, which does not accord with the characteristics of the moments of joy and the rest. Here "the aspect of generation" is held to be the very nature of the arising of the joys and the rest; it is not the characteristic of a deity arising from the transformation of the moon, the vajra and so forth. Why is that? When the moon of the mind of awakening drips from the wheel of great bliss and reaches the site of the sixteen-petaled lotus, in the first moment joy dawns. After that, when it pervades the joints of all the limbs, in the second moment supreme joy dawns. Then, when it reaches the tip of the vajra, in the third moment coemergent joy dawns. After that, when it spreads into the supreme limb, in the fourth moment the joy of cessation dawns. In this way the aspect of generation of the joys should be understood.

In order to teach the two truths of the coemergent, the ultimate and the conventional, it is said:

That itself is here twofold;
The fruit is held to be twofold:
One is like the sky,
The other like the full moon.

The first two lines teach it in brief, and the next two lines teach it in detail. It is explained once more by the verse beginning "From these, that which is like the sky." Here "like the sky" is that which is free from the duality of grasped and grasper, an essence that is not a substance, characterized as the experience of great bliss, the nature of reality that is self-awareness. That is "the protector": the protectors are the Blessed Buddhas, gathered as the nature of the five aggregates, and their dharmakāya is explained as the pervading essence, the utterly pure suchness, characterized as the great bliss of the coemergent that arises from the example.

"That which is like the full moon" means that whatever has the substantial character of the coemergent bliss that is the essence of the example is the saṃbhogakāya. Here it is the body of complete enjoyment because of complete enjoyment; that is, it shows that the nature of the bliss of the example is the saṃbhogakāya of the buddhas. The passage beginning "That itself is the wheel of yoginīs" fully teaches nothing other than the meaning just explained; it is not to be explained otherwise.

Now, in order to explain the limbs of the meditation on the coemergent, it is said, "Here this is the clear realization," and so on. "The lone hero" is said of the yogin who is free from the net of all conceptual thought. "Conceiving oneself as Heruka" means that the yogin who meditates on the generation stage, through the yoga of self in which one has intense conviction in one's own identity, fully imagines oneself as having the nature of Heruka. "Having drawn in with the mind any woman whatsoever" means: whoever it was who formerly, through embraces and the like when the yogin was engaged in joy, captivated his mind and became the cause of producing intense joy and the rest, that very woman one imagines as having the nature of Nairātmyā, the essence of the wisdom seal. "Or the play of kakkola and bola" means that one meditates on the play of the bola within the kakkola of that consort emanated by the mind; and this is connected with what follows above: "one should turn toward the ultimate, nondual wisdom." By this much the union with the

wisdom seal is taught.

Alternatively, through the passage beginning "In the opening of the bola," the instruction of the great seal is explained. In "meditating on the play of means and wisdom arising from one's own heart and navel," the navel is the center of the wheel of emanation; the wisdom abiding there is the first of the expanse, the essence of the Blessed Lady Nairātmyā. The means abiding at the heart is the sound of the clouds, the nature of glorious Heruka abiding at the center of the eight-petaled lotus. These, descending from one's own navel and heart, are the inner wisdom and means. When they reach the opening of the secret vajra, their play is whatever has the nature of the experience of great bliss; the yogin should meditate on that very thing, and "turning toward the ultimate" teaches that one should rely on being of one taste with it. By this much the union with the great seal is taught.

In the passage beginning "Having turned toward it in this way," that great bliss, whose essence is unsurpassed and nondual, is "without appearance and mere clarity." That in which there is no nature of conceptual thought, of grasped, grasper and so forth, is "without appearance." Yet even so, "mere clarity" means that, by its nature as self-awareness, it does not go beyond the quality of wisdom. "Infinite" refers to the essence of the dharmakāya, realized as having a nature without beginning or end. "One should view it for as long as one is able": here viewing means that one should thoroughly know its nature without interruption. By this much it teaches that, having viewed oneself as having the nature of coemergent great bliss, one should also view all things, moving and unmoving, as having that nature.

Here the reasoning is this. The nature of reality is the pervader; it is the dharmakāya, by nature luminous, whose nature is great bliss. That very great bliss pervades all phenomena. Since phenomena and the nature of reality are related by identity, all things, moving and unmoving, are established as nothing other than the nature of great bliss. As it is said, "The nature of reality is not different from phenomena."

Now, if one objects, "If that is so, then meditation is pointless," we reply: it does not already have the distinction of being purified of adventitious stains, and so meditation is not pointless. By this much the yoga of meditative equipoise is taught.

Through the passage beginning "Having arisen, too, all things," the second yoga, the yoga that is not in meditative equipoise, is taught. Here too it is only

the subject matter explained before, and that has already been explained. The two verses from the tantra beginning "All living beings arose from me" simply accord with the meaning just explained, and they are not to be explained otherwise. The yoga of rising is the yoga that is not in meditative equipoise. The words "again and again" show that both yogas are to be uninterrupted.

The verse beginning "Like the flowing of a river's stream" teaches the third yoga, which is that of suchness, distinct from the others. Just as the streams of water in a river flow without interruption, and just as the stream of a lamp's light flows, so one should abide in the yoga of suchness; this pervades both of the other yogas. It shows that the yogin should abide at all times in the yoga of natural suchness. Why is that? Because for one who does not know the yoga of suchness, even the yoga of meditative equipoise becomes like the yoga that is not in meditative equipoise; whereas for yogins who know the yoga of suchness, whatever actions of body, speech and mind they perform in the manner of the four modes of conduct, all of these become for them the nature of nondual wisdom.

The verse beginning "This self-aware wisdom" is a concluding verse and is easy to understand. The two verses beginning "Earth, water, fire" teach the benefit that comes about in this very life.

Now, through the passage beginning "The divisions of the states of this yoga," the samādhi just explained is taught as fourfold in its divisions of states. Here, since the coemergent yoga is of a single essence, it has no divisions of states; yet because it appears in successive aspects to the yogin who relies on it, the divisions of states are taught. Why is that? For one who is still training in the yoga of the completion stage, even though the taste is the single taste of the coemergent, at first it is seen as like clouds. In the same way it is to be realized progressively, each stage higher than the last. Although it is of a single essence, it appears to the world with various appearances: for example, to persons whose eye faculty is impaired or unimpaired, the disk of the moon appears as unclear or as clear, and so on. The disk of the moon has no nature of being clear or unclear, since it is the essence of pure appearance alone. Therefore the divisions of the states of yoga are taught in terms of the activity of the yogin who is still training.

To explain this very point, it is said, "Before accomplishment, like clouds," and so on. First of all, a disciple who has pleased the guru enters the maṇḍala, and then, through union with an action seal or a pledge seal, according to the rite,

obtains the wisdom-gnosis empowerment. When the guru, teaching in brief and in detail, points out the coemergent to the disciple, that is, for him, the state prior to accomplishment. Why is that? Because the coemergent is pointed out to that disciple at the time of empowerment, and not before. For if it had been done before, then the subsequent meditation, in the states like illusion and the rest, on the wisdom seal, the great seal, the action seal and the pledge seal, in that order, would become pointless; and if it were not pointed out, meditating on it would not be reasonable. Therefore "like clouds" should be understood as the time when the guru empowers the disciple through union with an action seal and a pledge seal.

To explain the reason for "like clouds," preceded by an example, it is said, "When covered by thin clouds," and so on. Just as the full moon covered by thin clouds is seen a little but not very clearly, so too, before accomplishment, in the state of one still training, the coemergent appears unclearly; thus it is taught as being like clouds.

In "When it is accomplished, like an illusion": whatever coemergent joy was pointed out before, that very joy, meditated on without interruption and always with faith, becomes the manifest accomplishment, and its arising is like this. Just as illusions arising from the power of jewels, medicines and mantras are seen even though they have no separate appearance of their own, so, through the power of the consort emanated by the mind, that is, through union with the wisdom seal, wisdom comes to dawn clearly. So "like an illusion" is taught specifically.

Then in the passage beginning "Like a dream": just as some, by falling asleep, experience nonconceptuality, so the yogin who meditates on the play of the means and wisdom of his inner nature, having meditated on the great seal, experiences the coemergent all at once in the sleep of yoga. So "like a dream" is taught.

Then in the passage beginning "Like dream and waking": the outer consorts are the two, the action seal and the pledge seal. Because it arises from union with the two seals, it is like waking. Because, through having made manifest the nonconceptual nature of reality, one's own body and the body of the wisdom consort are not apprehended even though they are present, it is like a dream. In "even when there is a cause of distraction," the cause of distraction is the characteristics of the two seals.

For a yogin abiding in the samādhi that is like dream and waking, even when there is a cause of distraction, the mind does not stray, because he is in meditative equipoise on what is stable. Yet his pledge is what is called union with the seal, and utter meditative equipoise itself is his vow. Since there is thus the union of pledge and vow, it is supreme above all the last. From the Hevajra, too, it is said:

At first it appears like clouds;
When accomplished, it becomes like an illusion;
All at once, it is like a dream;
Dream and waking are not different;
The characteristic of nondifference is accomplished;
The yoga of the seal is fully accomplished.

And so on. In the passage beginning "From the most profound Hevajra," it says, "Having completely abandoned the master's own invention, I have composed this treatise," and it teaches the full dedication of merit; that too is easy to understand.

Whatever virtue I have gathered
By composing this commentary
On the excellent coemergent yoga,
Through it may the world become one-pointed in the coemergent.

That which is not the domain of a mind of expressed and expression,
The sun that dispels the night of the mass of delusion,
Which fills every quarter of the directions with the light of its own self:
To the coemergent, like the sky and the full moon, I bow.

The Commentary on the Coemergent, called Fully Illuminating the Essence, on the work composed by the great scholar Ratnākaraśānti, composed by the great master of Oḍḍiyāna, the brahmin Thagana, is complete. It was translated and finalized by the paṇḍita, the great scholar Mantrakalakuśa.

Translator's Notes

• The Sanskrit title is given as spelled. In the third opening verse, "the glorious Ratnākara" most likely refers to Ratnākaraśānti, author of the root work on coemergent yoga commented on here and of the Garland of Pearls (Muktāvalī) on the Hevajra Tantra cited below. "Worthy of offering" in the second verse renders □□□□□□□□□□, which could also be read as a name (Yajñadatta); the reading is uncertain. In the quoted verse from the chapter on selflessness, "as is fitting is fire" reads □□ for the written □□ ("human"), and in the last quoted line the text's □□□□□□□ is taken as a slip for Heruka, which the commentary itself writes immediately after.

"Banner" and "supreme limb" are tantric code terms for the male and female organs; "lake-born one" is the lotus, and "lord of the stars" and "hare-marked one" are the moon, here the drop of the mind of awakening.
• The text writes □□□□□□□□□□ for the commentary's recurring term □□□□□□□□□, "concordant outflow," and this has been followed; likewise the quoted root phrase reads □□□□□ where the commentary's own gloss shows □□□□□, "play." Kakkola and bola are tantric code words for the female and male organs. "The first of the expanse" (for Nairātmyā at the navel) and "the sound of the clouds" (for Heruka at the heart) appear to be coded designations, probably of seed syllables; they are rendered literally. The four joys are given here in the order joy, supreme joy, coemergent joy, joy of cessation, as the text has them.
• The answer to the opening objection is terse; it has been taken to mean that the nature of reality, though pervading all, is not yet purified of adventitious stains in the practitioner, so that meditation still has a purpose. The four seals (action seal, pledge seal, wisdom seal and great seal) are matched with the four states of the coemergent yoga: like clouds, like an illusion, like a dream, and like dream and waking.
• "Supreme above all the last" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ literally; it appears to mean that this fourth and last state is the highest of all the states. The colophon is read as naming Ratnākaraśānti as author of the root work and the brahmin Thagana of Oḍḍiyāna as author of this commentary; the Tibetan is compressed and could also be taken differently. The translator's name is written □□□□□□□□□□□□□□ and is given as spelled; it may stand for Mantrakalaśa.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.